

THE MASTER'S UNIVERSITY
JOURNAL
of
BIBLICAL AND THEOLOGICAL STUDIES

VOLUME 1



SPRING 2024

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THE MASTER'S UNIVERSITY JOURNAL OF
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published by

THE SCHOOL OF BIBLICAL STUDIES

of

THE MASTER'S UNIVERSITY

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The Master's University Journal of Biblical and Theological Studies features articles written by students during the course of their studies at The Master's University. It is published in print and distributed electronically. For information about articles, policy, or journal access, contact bible@masters.edu.

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PASSING OVER THE BLOODY BRIDEGROOM: EXODUS 4:24-26 IN ITS BIBLICAL-THEOLOGICAL CONTEXT

Zachary Urdaneta¹

* * * * *

Moses and Israel both embark on an exodus. The two exodus accounts turn on the hinge of a strange and graphic passage. In Exodus 4:24-26, Yahweh comes by night to put Moses to death for failing to circumcise his son. Despite difficult syntax, careful study reveals the biblical-theological significance of this narrative. The bloody circumcision of Moses's firstborn son causes Yahweh to leave Moses unharmed in a type of the Passover, foreshadowing the bloody sacrifices of the firstborn lambs that cause Yahweh to pass over the nation of Israel.

Key words: circumcision, Exodus, Moses, covenant, blood, Passover

* * * * *

The book of Exodus contains two accounts of salvation. The exodus of Israel receives the most attention, as God frees his people from slavery through miracles. Israel's exodus from Egypt, however, is actually the second exodus in the book. The first four chapters of Exodus focus on the exodus of Israel's leader, Moses. The Lord rescues Moses from Pharaoh so that Moses can rescue Israel from Pharaoh. Moses is threatened by Pharaoh, saved among the reeds of the Nile, sent out into the wilderness, and brought to "the mountain of God—Horeb," where Yahweh appears to him (Exod 2:3-10, 15; 3:1-6).² In a parallel fashion, Israel is threatened by Pharaoh, saved in the Sea of Reeds, sent out into the wilderness, and brought to Mount Horeb, where Yahweh appears to them. In the words of John Currid, "The structure casts the early life of Moses as a prototype and microcosm for the exodus event."³

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² Translations of Scripture are the author's.

³ Currid goes on to say, "The episodes of the life of Moses in Egypt, Midian, and Sinai model and prefigure the salient events in the life of the emerging nation of Israel." He cites Moses's slavery, water

The climax of Israel's exodus is the Passover, yet the almost-perfect paradigm set by Moses appears to lack the essential salvific event. Although it may not be obvious at first, Moses himself experienced a Passover. In fact, the Passover account in Exodus 11–12 is written in the pattern of Moses's Passover in his own exodus. Unfortunately, Exodus 4:24–26 is often overlooked, misinterpreted, and considered unconnected to the greater biblical-theological context of Exodus.⁴ This paper will argue that Moses wrote his personal Passover in Exodus 4:24–26 to function as a paradigm for Israel's Passover.⁵ After considering the narrative context, I will then translate and exegete this passage, analyzing it in its narrative and theological context. God completes the exodus of Moses with a dramatic shedding of blood, covering his covenant transgression and completing his identity as a member of Israel. Zipporah saves and receives her “bridegroom of blood” (4:25), marking the family's full membership in the covenant community. The circumcision of Gershom saves Moses from Yahweh in a Passover, allowing him to return to Egypt and lead Israel in the exodus through the greater Passover.

The Context of Exodus 4:24–26

The context of the bloody bridegroom narrative can be viewed through three lenses: women, identity, and the covenant of circumcision. First, the salvation of Moses by women is a common thread throughout the opening chapters of Exodus, climaxing with Zipporah's intervention in 4:24–26. Second, Moses has a complex national identity, volleying between Hebrew, Egyptian, and Midianite. This narrative answers the question of his identity once and for all. Finally, circumcision—specifically its covenantal inauguration in Genesis 17—serves as the theological foundation for the bloody bridegroom text. His failure to circumcise his son constitutes a breaking of the covenant and excludes his participation in it. His obedience to the covenant command resolves this tension. The threads of salvation by women, identity, and circumcision in Genesis 17 and Exodus 1–3 are the foundation of the literary and thematic context of Exodus 4:24–26.

salvation, escape to Midian, theophany, and hesitation as five points of contact between the exoduses of Moses and Israel (2:1–2, 3–10, 11–22; 3:1–22; 4:1–17). However, he notably does not reference Exodus 4:24–26, nor does he note a Passover connection between Moses and Israel. John D. Currid, “Exodus,” in *A Biblical-Theological Introduction to the Old Testament: The Gospel Promised*, ed. Miles V. Van Pelt (Wheaton, IL: Crossway, 2016), 99–100.

⁴ Cornelis Houtman says Exodus 4:24–26 “is a passage causing exegetical headaches.” He further cites writers from antiquity and the New Testament period who ignored or softened the importance of the event (Cornelis Houtman, *Exodus*, vol. 1, Historical Commentary on the Old Testament [Kampen, NL: Kok, 1993], 432, 439).

Propp opens his renowned article, “‘The object of our inquiry is among the most controverted passages of Scripture.’ The cliché applies nowhere better than to Exod. iv 24–6, the so-called ‘bloody bridegroom’ story.” William H. Propp, “That Bloody Bridegroom (Exodus iv 24–6),” *Vetus Testamentum* 43, no. 4 (October 1993), 495.

⁵ The Passover and the Exodus itself are of course the biblical paradigms for redemption. James Hamilton writes that Moses “establishes the events of the exodus as a type, and later biblical authors show in their work that they have learned from Moses that the exodus is both an interpretive schema and a predictive paradigm.” James M. Hamilton Jr., *Typology: Understanding the Bible's Promise-Shaped Patterns: How Old Testament Expectations Are Fulfilled in Christ* (Grand Rapids: Zondervan Academic, 2022), 256.

Women

In Exodus 1, Pharaoh commands the Hebrew midwives when delivering a baby boy, to “put him to death” (Exod 1:16). Shiphrah and Puah, presumably the head midwives, “feared God and they did not do according to what the king of Egypt had spoken to them, but let the boys live” (1:17).⁶ The midwives’ pattern of obedience to Yahweh allows Moses to live, marking the first-time women save him (2:2). But when baby Moses can no longer be hidden, he is placed among the reeds of the Nile (בְּסוּף; 2:3), foreshadowing Israel passing through the Sea of Reeds (יַם־סוּף; 10:19; 13:18). His mother, the second woman in the book to rescue him, hides him for his safety as his sister Miriam stands by to watch (2:2-5). Then, the daughter of Pharaoh delivers Moses and his ark from the waters of the river and has “compassion upon him” (2:5-6). Miriam, likely fearing the death of her baby brother, intercedes, offering to bring a Hebrew woman to nurse the boy (2:7). In this way, the daughter of Pharaoh and the sister of Moses become the third and fourth women to rescue him. Yahweh uses the midwives, Moses’s mother, Pharaoh’s daughter, and Moses’s sister to save him from death.

The bloody bridegroom narrative is the capstone to this theme of salvation by women. Zipporah, Moses’s wife, saves him from the messenger of Yahweh who sought “to put him to death” (הָמִיתוֹ; 4:24). The *hiphil* infinitive construct form of מוֹת in 4:24 links back to the *hiphil we-qatal* form of מוֹת used by Pharaoh in 1:16 to form an inclusio. Moses is in the exact same danger in Exodus 4 as he was eighty years prior as a baby. Yahweh uses women to save Moses from death in Exodus 1–2, and he continues this pattern in 4:24-26. The exodus of Moses is bookended by his salvation from death by women.

Identity

A crucial question in the exodus of Moses is his national identity. In Exodus 1:1–2:6, Moses is presented as a Hebrew boy who must escape the threat of Pharaoh through an exodus. His status as a Hebrew is affirmed by Pharaoh’s daughter as she says, “This is one of the Hebrew boys” (2:6; מִן־הָעִבְרִיִּים זֶה).⁷ It is also confirmed by his descent from two parents of the tribe of Levi (2:1). After being nursed, Moses is adopted by Pharaoh’s daughter (2:10). Alexander states that the Egyptian princess’s act of naming “is her claim to Moses as her own son,”⁸ resulting in a shift of Moses’s

⁶ For the argument that Shiphrah and Puah are the leaders of the midwives, see Douglas K. Stuart, *Exodus: An Exegetical and Theological Exposition of Holy Scripture*, New American Commentary (Nashville: Broadman & Holman, 2006), 76.

⁷ The woman could have simply said that he was a יֶלֶד עִבְרִית (a Hebrew boy). The partitive מִן and singular זה emphasize that Moses is merely one out of many Hebrew boys, re-enforcing that he is identified as an Israelite. Stuart provides an interesting possible explanation of how Pharaoh’s daughter knew Moses was a Hebrew baby boy: “Her recognition that Moses was a Hebrew boy . . . probably was predicated on four things at least: the general physical differences between Hebrews and Egyptians, the type of baby clothes used, the fact that her discovery occurred in an Israelite settlement area, and the general situation (the need to hide Israelite baby boys but not Egyptian baby boys).” Ibid., 91.

⁸ T. Desmond Alexander, *Exodus*, Apollos Old Testament Commentary (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity Press, 2017), 62.

identity. With regards to his upbringing, Moses is an Egyptian, which is affirmed by the Midianite shepherdess identifying him as such (2:19).

Years after his adoption, Moses goes out “to his brothers” and sees “an Egyptian striking a Hebrew, one of his brothers” (Exod 2:11). This verse portrays Moses as Hebrew, not Egypt.⁹ Moses kills the Egyptian, and after Pharaoh hears of the murder, he flees to the wilderness (2:12-15). Yet while Moses disassociates himself from the Egyptians, he is not yet fully Hebrew, for he marries Zipporah the Midianitess and lives with her family (2:15-22). Midian and his offspring were the descendants of Abraham and Keturah (Gen 25:1-2), not Isaac, the child of promise. So, for forty years, Moses dwells with those who are ethnically outside the Abrahamic covenant.

However, Moses does not become a Midianite, and in Exodus 3, God establishes his identity once and for all, saying, “I am the God of your father, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of Jacob” (Exod 3:6). Moses will not serve the Egyptian gods, but the God of the Abrahamic covenant. Just as Yahweh appeared to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, so his messenger appeared to Moses (3:3),¹⁰ placing a special calling on Moses’s life as with the patriarchs.¹¹ Moses may be an Egyptian by adoption and a Midianite by marriage, but he is first and foremost a Hebrew. Having identified Moses as a member of the covenant community, Yahweh then commissions Moses to go and lead his people in the exodus. Yet there is one aspect of Moses’s Hebrew status that is still in question, for those who true members of the covenant must receive its sign.

Circumcision

When Moses sees the burning bush, Yahweh calls him to participate in the Abrahamic covenant and take part in the fulfillment of his promise to bring his people back to the land of Canaan (Gen 15:16; Exod 3:6). Yet, Moses has been living first as an Egyptian and then as a Midianite. He is married to Zipporah with whom he has two sons, Gershom and Eliezer. Therefore, Moses and his family must become full members of the covenant community. Resolving to obey God, he “took his wife and his sons and he mounted them upon the donkey, and he returned to the land of Egypt” (Exod 4:20). However, as the bloody bridegroom narrative shows in 4:24-26, Moses’s son has not yet been circumcised.

⁹ Stuart, *Exodus*, 95. See also Brevard S. Childs, *The Book of Exodus: A Critical, Theological Commentary* (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1974), 30.

¹⁰ The ordinary translation of מַלְאָךְ and ἄγγελος is “angel.” I have chosen the more generic term “messenger” to translate the words in order to reflect the broad usage of this term in the Old Testament. The texts referring to the messenger of the Lord emphasize his status as Yahweh’s representative, or messenger, not his spiritual or possible angelic character.

¹¹ God opens his call to Moses with the two-fold repetition of his name, “Moses, Moses” (Exod 3:4), as he called Abraham (Gen 22:11) and Jacob (Gen 46:2). Moses responds to God’s call with “Here I am” (הִנְנִי; Exod 3:4) and so do Abraham (הִנְנִי; Gen 22:11) and Jacob (הִנְנִי; Gen 46:2). Although Isaac is never greeted with his repeated name and does not respond with “Here I am,” Genesis makes it clear that the line flows from Abraham, through him, to Jacob. God affirms Isaac’s status and role in the covenantal plans in Genesis 26:24. The similar callings of Moses, Abraham, and Jacob are part of a larger thread tying Abraham and Jacob to the story of the Exodus. Hamilton rightly argues that Moses “wrote the narratives so that the exodus pattern is typified in the lives of Abraham and Jacob, then the exodus itself happened when God brought Israel out of Egypt, and Moses indicated that his audience could expect God to continue to act in the same way in the future.” Hamilton, *Typology*, 256.

God told Abraham, “Walk before me and be blameless, so that I may confirm my covenant between me and you, and so that I may multiply you with great excess” (Gen 17:1-2). Alexander argues from the Hebrew syntax that this is a purpose-result clause: “These must be obeyed before the covenant will be established. The Lord will ratify the covenant only if Abraham walks before God and is blameless.”¹² Abraham is called to obey in order to receive the covenant blessings. This is expanded in 17:9, when “God said to Abraham, ‘As for you, you shall keep (שמר) my covenant, you and your seed after you throughout their generations.’” For Abraham and his seed, this obedience is in the form of circumcision.

To participate in the Abrahamic covenant, obedience is required by God, who said to Abraham, “This is my covenant, which you shall keep, between me and you and your descendants after you: every male among you shall be circumcised . . . every male among you who is eight days old shall be circumcised throughout your generations” (Gen 17:10, 12). In the words of Samuel Renihan, “This is a demand for strict obedience from Abraham and his descendants. The way in which they will keep the covenant is the circumcision of all males on the eighth day after their birth.”¹³ Circumcision is necessary for participation in the covenant. The penalty for breaking the covenant by not cutting off the foreskin is to be cut off from the covenant itself. God says to Abraham that “an uncircumcised male who is not circumcised in the flesh of his foreskin, that person shall be cut off from his people. He has broken my covenant” (Gen 17:14). Hamilton puts it well, “Here is the choice: be cut or be cut off.”¹⁴ This cutting off could refer to excommunication from the covenant community or to execution.¹⁵ In the nation of Israel, the community would have performed the excommunication or execution to cut off the uncircumcised. However, in Genesis 17:14, the text does not say who will do the cutting off or how they will do it before the establishment of Israel. All the reader knows is that God will judge the uncircumcised by cutting them off. Circumcision is the necessary step of obedience to participate in the covenant community. This is the step of obedience that Moses failed to take with his son.

Moses has been saved from death by women to enter his new identity as a Hebrew and a member of the Abrahamic covenant. However, in order to be a member of the community, Moses and his household must be circumcised. Moses travels to Egypt, but he is traveling with his uncircumcised son. Unlike Abraham, he did not express faith in the covenant promises of God by circumcising his son. He cannot be a member of the community, so he must be cut off. To complete the exodus, Moses needs a Passover.

¹² T. Desmond Alexander, *From Paradise to the Promised Land: An Introduction to the Pentateuch*, 4th ed. (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2022), 74. He further notes, “Whereas the promissory covenant of Genesis 15 is unconditional, the establishment or ratification of the covenant of circumcision depends on Abraham’s continuing obedience to God” (73).

¹³ Samuel Renihan, *The Mystery of Christ, His Covenant, and His Kingdom* (Cape Coral, FL: Founders, 2020), 92. For an exposition of the covenant of circumcision as a covenant of works and its correlation to the Mosaic covenant, see Renihan, 87–101.

¹⁴ Victor P. Hamilton, *The Book of Genesis, Chapters 1–17*, *The New International Commentary on the Old Testament* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1990), 249.

¹⁵ *Ibid.*, 250.

Exegesis of Exodus 4:24-26

וַיְהִי בַדֶּרֶךְ בְּמִלּוֹן וַיִּפְגְּשֵׁהוּ יְהוָה וַיִּבְקֶשׁ הָמִיתוֹ 4:24

“And it came to pass on the way, at the lodging-place, that Yahweh met him and sought to put him to death.”

The text of Exodus 4:24 opens with the macro-syntactical marker וַיְהִי (“and it came to pass”),¹⁶ frequently used in Hebrew narrative as a transition device. How does this opening verb mark a narrative change? The structure of Exodus 3:1–4:17 begins with the messenger of Yahweh appearing to Moses and conversing with him. Following this, there are several shifts in the narrative in 4:18-31. In 4:18-19, Moses receives permission from Jethro and a command from Yahweh to return to Egypt. A summary statement is then given in 4:20, as “Moses took his wife and his sons and he mounted them upon the donkey and he returned to the land of Egypt, and Moses took the staff of God in his hand.” As Moses and his family begin their travel, Yahweh gives him instructions in 4:21-23. The purpose of Moses’s journey is to perform the wonders that God has given him (4:21). The purpose of the wonders is to create an opportunity for Yahweh to harden Pharaoh’s heart, which will result in the death of his firstborn (4:23). The outcome of this return to Egypt is Yahweh taking revenge for his firstborn son—Israel—by killing Pharaoh’s firstborn. The return narrative is marked by a summary statement (4:20), a mission statement (4:21-23), a meeting with Yahweh (4:24-26), a meeting with Aaron (4:27-28), and the belief of Israel (4:29-31).

Return Narrative

- A. Summary Statement: Moses returned to Egypt (4:20)
- B. Mission Statement: Death of the firstborn (4:21-23)
- C. Meeting (פגש) with Yahweh: The bloody bridegroom (4:24-26)
- D. Meeting (פגש) with Aaron: Words and signs (4:27-28)
- E. Belief of Israel: Return completed (4:29-31)

The three middle units, i.e., the mission statement, the meeting with Yahweh, and the meeting with Aaron, all prepare Moses to return to Egypt. This first verb of verse 24, וַיְהִי (“And it came to pass”), serves to set the meeting with Yahweh within the return narrative of 4:20-31.¹⁷

Moses, Zipporah, and their sons Gershom and Eliezer are on the way to Egypt. As they are on the way (בדרך), they come to the lodging-place (במלון).¹⁸ A מלון is “the

¹⁶ וַיְהִי, *Qal, wayyiqtol*, 3MS, “and it came to pass.”

¹⁷ Sarna (*Exodus*, 24) argues “the sketchy tale of the night incident in verses 24-26 is not as unconnected with the larger context as if often claimed.” Thus, he says, “The introductory phrase . . . immediately establishes the chronological linkage with verse 20.” Similarly, Koowon Kim writes, “Verse 24 reads most naturally as a narrative sequence of v. 20,” and he argues that 4:21-23 serves to connect 4:24-26 “to the broader context of redemptive history.” Koowon Kim, “A Christotelic Interpretation of Exodus 4:24-26,” *Asia Journal of Theology* 29, no. 1 (April 2015), 10.

¹⁸ The lodging-place, מלון, is used eight times in the Hebrew Bible and is a derivative of the verb לָן—to spend the night.

place where people with their animals can find shelter for the night.”¹⁹ The use of this word sets the location and the time of the attack (at night).²⁰ This may have simply been a place where Moses and his family set up camp,²¹ or an established overnight location.²² Either way, Moses and his family are at a place of safety and rest, presumably asleep. Any sort of encounter or attack would have been unexpected.

The attack of 4:24 is not only unexpected but also ambiguous. The text says “that Yahweh met him and sought to put him to death” (4:24). “Met him” translates ויפגשו, which is a general verb for encountering or meeting someone, usually in the course of travel.²³ By itself, the verb does not imply a negative or positive encounter. It is used in identical form for Aaron’s meeting with Moses (4:27), clearly there in a positive context.²⁴ The following phrase in verse 24 is what gives it a negative connotation, “and he sought to put him to death” (וַיִּבְרֹאשׁ אֹתוֹ). This is not a chance passing by between two travelers on a journey.²⁵ The infinitive construct, הַמִּיתוֹ, indicates the purpose of God arranging this encounter—to put Moses to death. Yahweh is here to carry out a judicial judgment, to execute Moses.²⁶ There is something wrong in this narrative, and it is not Yahweh’s impending execution of an individual. Someone must be put to death for an action they have taken or failed to take. Herein lies the text’s ambiguity.

The reader knows that Yahweh is meeting Moses but does not know who Yahweh is going to execute. The object of the verb הַמִּיתוֹ (to put him to death) is only marked by the third-person, masculine singular pronominal suffix. Speculations about his identity abound among rabbis, scholars, and translations. Pettit qualifies the search for the criminal by writing, “The pronoun has no clear antecedent, and it is therefore not clear who has come under attack. We may presume in light of the masculine pronoun that it is either Moses or one of his sons.”²⁷ Zipporah, as both a female and the heroine of this attack (4:25) is certainly not the one facing death.

¹⁹ Houtman, *Exodus*, 433. See also Bob Becking, “Then Zipporah Took a Flint ... *Circumcision as a Rite of Passage in Exod 4.24-26*,” *Scandinavian Journal of the Old Testament* 37, no. 1 (January 2, 2023), 4.

²⁰ William H. Propp, *Exodus 1-18*, Anchor Yale Bible Commentaries (New Haven, CT: Yale, 1999), 218.

²¹ Childs, *Exodus*, 103.

²² As reflected by the LXX’s translation, καταλύματι—inn. Houtman takes this to mean the translators of the LXX understood Moses placing his family in a shelter, instead of the open air. Houtman, *Exodus*, 434.

There was no room for Christ at the καταλύματι (Luke 2:7), and there was no room for Moses with his uncircumcised son at the καταλύματι.

²³ Francis Brown, Samuel R. Driver, and Charles A. Briggs, “פגשׁ” In *Enhanced Brown-Driver-Briggs Hebrew and English Lexicon* (Oxford: Clarendon, 1977), 803.

²⁴ Houtman notes, “Just as in 4:27 the encounter leads to touching, an embrace as a sign of affection, so in 4:24 the touching expresses the desire to kill.” Houtman, *Exodus*, 434.

²⁵ Becking differs, writing, “The verb has the connotation of a fortuitous meeting; the encounter was not planned but took place accidentally,” citing Genesis 32:18 in support. However, Exodus 4:27 shows that chance is not inherent in the meaning of פגשׁ, as Yahweh commands Aaron to meet (לִקְרָאתָ) Moses, and Aaron obeys by going to meet him (וַיִּפְגַּשׁהוּ). Aaron did not encounter Moses by chance but sought him out. Becking, “Then Zipporah Took a Flint,” 4.

²⁶ Propp writes, “Although the causative of mw, ‘die’ can be synonymous with hrg ‘kill,’ hemit often has judicial connotations comparable to English ‘execute’ (e.g., Num 35:19, 21). The subject of hemit is frequently Yahweh, whose decrees are by definition justice; cf. 2Kgs 5:7: ‘Am I Deity, to put to death (lahamit) or to let live?’” Propp, *Exodus*, 218–19.

²⁷ David P. Pettit, “When the Lord Seeks to Kill Moses: Reading Exodus 4.24-26 in Its Literary Context,” *Journal for the Study of the Old Testament* 40, no. 2 (December 2015), 169.

Several scholars view the referent of the pronominal suffix to be Gershom, not Moses. Although not taking this approach, Alexander cites two common reasons to prefer Gershom over Moses: the fact that Moses is not explicitly named, while 4:21-23 focuses on firstborn sons, and the question of why Yahweh would harm an obedient Moses (4:19-20) who is journeying to Egypt as commanded.²⁸ For Stuart, the exclusion of the name Moses is enough to assume that one of his sons is in view, and he seeks to demonstrate the coherence of the text if Gershom is assumed.²⁹

Adam Howell has written the most substantial defense of the Gershom view, arguing that “when vv. 24-26 are read following vv. 21-23, the most natural antecedent of the personal pronouns in vv. 24-26 seems to be Gershom, Moses’s firstborn.”³⁰ While it is true that 4:21-23 focuses on the impending death of Pharaoh’s firstborn in light of his persecution of God’s firstborn, this does not require the object of 4:24 to be the firstborn of Moses. Although Pharaoh’s firstborn is highlighted in 4:23, the recipient of the instructions is Moses (4:21-23). The emphasis in 4:21-23, as part of the return narrative (4:20-31), is to prepare Moses for Egypt through instruction. The key individual in the return narrative is Moses. The actions in the summary statement (4:20) are performed by Moses. The instructions are given to Moses (4:21-23). Moses has a meeting with Aaron (4:27-29). Moses and Aaron gather the elders of Israel (4:29-31). Although firstborn sons are mentioned in 4:21-23, the focus remains on Moses, as the recipient of God’s instructions and the executor of his judgment. Howell also views the rectification of the situation via circumcision as further evidence that Gershom was to have been killed, had he not been circumcised.³¹ However, children were not responsible for circumcising. The anchor text for circumcision, Genesis 17:10-14, makes it clear that the responsibility to circumcise was on the father, not the child.³² This command would be codified in the Mosaic Law, as Moses would command that when a male is born, “on the eighth day, the flesh of his foreskin shall be circumcised” (Lev 12:3). Gershom should certainly have been circumcised, but he was not at fault for his lack of circumcision.³³

Since Gershom and Eliezer are not likely candidates for divine judgment in Exodus 4:24, we are left with Moses. The reasons for identifying the referent of the pronominal suffix as Moses are convincing. Moses is the last-named person in the narrative (4:21) and as such, would not need to be re-introduced again. As the most recently addressed person, he is the most natural antecedent to the third-person suffixes in 4:24. The dialogue of 4:21-23 stands between the summary statement (4:20) and the meeting with Yahweh (4:24-26). As noted above, Moses is the focus in each unit of the return narrative (4:20-31).³⁴ It would be odd to shift the focus of

²⁸ Alexander, *Exodus*, 106–7.

²⁹ Stuart, *Exodus*, 152–56.

³⁰ Howell, Adam J. “The Firstborn Son of Moses as the ‘Relative of Blood’ in Exodus 4.24-26.” *Journal for the Study of the Old Testament* 35, no. 1 (September 2010), 67.

³¹ *Ibid.*, 68.

³² This is true, not only of newborn children who were to be circumcised on the eighth day (Gen 17:12) but of every male of any age. The command is that males are to “be circumcised,” as מִלֵּא is used six times in the *Niphal* in Genesis 17:10-14, indicating passive action.

³³ Alexander further notes, “In the light of God’s compassion for the Israelite firstborn males it seems inconsistent to suggest that he wants to kill Gershom.” Alexander, *Exodus*, 107.

³⁴ Pettit, “When the Lord Seeks to Kill Moses,” 169.

the narrative without naming the new individual.³⁵ Further, the one circumcised is identified in 4:25 as Zipporah's son. If he was the object of Yahweh's attack in 4:24, why was he not designated as the son of Zipporah or Moses there?³⁶ Zipporah adds another dimension to the argument for Moses, as she is the one who rises to the aid of the one being attacked. Childs uses this as his primary argument for Moses, writing, "The fact that Zipporah took the lead in circumcising the child is another indication that Moses was under attack and incapable of responding."³⁷ It would be extremely odd for Gershom to be attacked, and for Zipporah to rise to his aid instead of Moses, especially since Moses had already experienced multiple encounters with Yahweh. The two verbs themselves strengthen the argument for Moses as the object of their pronominal suffix. As noted previously, פגש (meet) is used for Aaron's meeting with Moses (4:27). Second, מות (death) in the *hiphil* was used for Moses, among the rest of the Hebrew babies, when Pharaoh says to the midwives, "If he is a son, then you shall put him to death" (וְהָמָתוֹ; 1:16). In conclusion, the majority view—that Moses is the one to be executed—is well substantiated.³⁸ Moses is the intended referent of the third masculine singular suffix in 4:24. He is the object of God's anger. As Moses and his family lie sleeping at the lodging-place, Yahweh meets him to put him to death.

וַתִּקַּח צִפּוֹרָה צִר וַתִּכְרֹת אֶת־עֶרְלַת בְּנָהּ וַתַּגַּע לְרַגְלָיו וַתֹּאמֶר כִּי חֲסִין־דָּמִים אָחָה לִּי 4:25
 "So Zipporah took a flint and she cut the foreskin of her son and she caused *it* to touch his feet. And she said, 'Surely you are a bridegroom of blood to me.'"

The narrative continues in 4:25, showing Zipporah's surprising response to her husband's impending death: taking a flint to cut off the foreskin of her son.³⁹ The lack of circumcision of Zipporah's son shows that Moses had not walked in full

³⁵ Propp writes, "Were it the child, the text would read 'sought to put Moses' son to death.'" Propp, "That Bloody Bridegroom (Exodus iv 24-6)," 499. Alexander (*Exodus*, 107) concurs, "Had the narrator intended the reader to understand that the life of one of Moses' sons was threatened, he would surely have identified him clearly at this stage."

³⁶ Kim says that if the son of Moses was attacked, "the mention of 'her son' in v. 25 would have been redundant." Kim, "Christotelic Interpretation," 6.

³⁷ Childs, *Exodus*, 103. Hamilton makes the same observation, "one would think that if it was the son whose life was in danger, Moses would have been the one to leap into action instead of being passive." Hamilton, *Exodus*, 82. Houtman asks the question, "Remarkable is that the circumcision is done by Zipporah, a duty not elsewhere in the OT performed by women. Does the task fall to her because Moses, owing to the threat on his life, was unable to do it?" Houtman, *Exodus*, 437. Thomas Dozeman would answer in the affirmative, as he concludes, "The action of Zipporah as a rescuer suggests that Moses is the object of the divine attack, since his salvation by women is a central theme in the opening chapters of Exodus." Thomas B. Dozeman, *Exodus*, Eerdmans Critical Commentary (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2009), 155.

³⁸ Dumbrell notes, "The Syriac text twice inserts 'Moses' into this verse, as the subject of the sentence and as the object of *mūt*, but this is an obvious intrusion designed to clarify a difficult context." William J. Dumbrell, "Exodus 4:24-26: A Textual Re-Examination," *Harvard Theological Review* 65, no. 2 (April 1972), 285.

³⁹ "Flint" (צִר) simply refers to a flint rock, and the plural is paired with הרבות (cut) in another circumcision account, to mean flint knives (Josh 5:2-3). Joshua 5 features a circumcision with flint knives (5:2-8) followed by the celebration of the Passover (5:10-11). Exodus 4 features a circumcision with flint followed by the Passover of Moses, as will be developed in this paper.

obedience and faith to the Abrahamic covenant.⁴⁰ As Alexander rightly explains, “Moses’ failure to circumcise his own son, as required by the covenant of circumcision previously inaugurated with the patriarch Abraham, placed Gershom outside the benefits of the covenant. The failure to circumcise Gershom rests with Moses and so he is the one threatened with punishment.”⁴¹ His failure to circumcise his son shows his lack of faith in God’s covenant promises. Zipporah responds to Moses’s peril by circumcising her son. This demonstrates that the lack of circumcision was the reason for Yahweh’s attack on his servant. As a result, Childs argues that the story “serves to dramatize the tremendous importance of circumcision.”⁴² Moses was to lead the nation of Israel out of Egypt to serve Yahweh, yet he himself had failed to lead his family in faith and obedience to the Abrahamic covenant.

What Zipporah does next is even more surprising. After cutting the foreskin, “She caused *it* to touch his feet.” Her action of touching (וַתַּגֵּעַ) is an unusual word choice. Had Moses wanted to communicate her throwing the foreskin, he could have used שָׁלַךְ—throw or cast.⁴³ Instead, he intentionally uses the verb for touching to describe what Zipporah does with the foreskin. The verse depicts Zipporah taking the cut-off foreskin of her son, bending down, and touching it to the feet of Moses. Significantly, Moses uses the *hiphil* form of נָגַע (touch) only one other time in Exodus: “And you shall take a bunch of hyssop and dip it in the blood which is in the basin, and you shall cause some of the blood which is in the basin to touch [וְהִגַּעְתֶּם] the lintel and the two doorposts” (Exod 12:22). When Moses instructed Israel to bring out and slaughter the Passover lambs, they were to take some of the blood of the lamb and cause it to touch (נָגַע) the lintel and the two doorposts of their houses. The blood that they touched the house with would be seen by Yahweh, who would then pass over that house (12:13). In the same way that the lintels and doorposts of the Israelite houses are touched with the blood of the Passover lambs, so Moses’s feet are touched with the bloody foreskin of Gershom. The spilled blood of the Passover lamb was made to touch the house, to stand between Israel and Yahweh. The spilled blood of Gershom was made to touch the feet, to stand between Moses and Yahweh. The salvation of Moses is described with the language of the Passover. He is saved in a Passover, to prepare him to lead Israel in *the* Passover.

Zipporah then turns to her husband and declares, “Surely you are a bridegroom of blood to me” (4:25). Opinions on the meaning of חתן (“bridegroom” or “relative”) and דָּמִים (“bloods,” masculine plural) are copious. After rectifying her son’s lack of circumcision and causing his foreskin to touch the feet of her husband, Zipporah

⁴⁰ Childs says that this is the earliest Jewish interpretation. “Rabbinic midrashim (Mekilta, Exodus Rabbah) developed the idea that Moses had failed to circumcise the child by the eighth day. Various reasons were offered for the omission—he had been prevented by his father-in-law (Targum Onkelos, Neofiti I, Jer. Targum); he had been negligent for an hour—but all focused on the seriousness of the failure to perform the rite which almost cost him his life.” Childs, *Exodus*, 96.

⁴¹ Alexander, *Exodus*, 107. Hamilton (*Exodus*, 82) concurs, “The reason for the attack . . . [is] Moses’s failure, for whatever reason, to minister paternally to his son by circumcising him.”

⁴² Childs, *Exodus*, 104.

⁴³ Moses uses שָׁלַךְ 22 times in the Torah, meaning “throw” every time (except Gen 21:15). Nine of these occurrences are in Exodus: 1:22; 4:3; 7:9, 10, 12; 15:25; 22:30; 32:19; 32:24. On the other hand, he uses “touch” (נָגַע) seven times in Exodus, and 54 times in the Torah, referring to touching, not throwing, every time.

issues this strange declaration. The narrator then repeats her words in the final phrase of the bloody bridegroom meeting, offering it as a sort of summary statement (4:26). The word חתן refers to a bridegroom or a son-in-law.⁴⁴ While it may be used as a general term for a male relative, it would still be an unusual choice if Zipporah's words were directed at Gershom. As shown above, the object of Yahweh's attack is Moses (4:24), and his feet are touched with the bloody foreskin of his son (4:25). Given this context, Zipporah's declaration refers to Moses. Zipporah stoops to touch the feet of Moses with the blood of their son, and then looks at him and calls him her bloody bridegroom. This is not the consummation of their marriage, but a reconfirmation of "the marriage bond between herself and Moses."⁴⁵ A fuller understanding of "bridegroom" requires a careful examination of "blood."

If "bridegroom" (חתן) refers to Moses as Zipporah's husband, how should "blood" (דמים) be interpreted? The first point of significance is that the plural form is used for blood (*damim*, literally "bloods.") Blood in the plural often refers to murder, bloodshed, or blood-guiltiness. The first uses of *damim* are in reference to the shed blood of the murdered Abel (Gen 4:10-11). There, the blood of the victim cries to Yahweh and is received by the ground. The next occurrence of דמים is here in Exodus 4:25-26. Propp sees a connection between the two texts and argues that the term describes "either the blood shed by a killer . . . or the miasma of guilt clinging to perpetrators of heinous crimes and to their land."⁴⁶ Propp best represents the view that understands the phrase "bridegroom of blood" to be Zipporah's realization of Moses's guilt for murdering an Egyptian (2:11-12).⁴⁷ Moses had murdered an Egyptian and fled to Midian, which functioned like a city of refuge for him according to Propp and writers following his tradition. Kim notes that "living in the city of refuge does not expiate a murderer's bloodguilt, which must be paid either by his own death or someone else's."⁴⁸ He thus regards Moses as a murderer who is attempting to leave the city of refuge (Midian, or the mountain of God; Exod 3:1). Moses is a man of bloodshed, which is why, according to Propp, Yahweh is about to execute him. "When Yahweh attacks Moses, Zipporah realizes that the violent stranger she married is a felon."⁴⁹ Kim provides a concise summary of this view: "Unless blood was shed, Moses's bloodguilt would remain with him and Yahweh would not allow him to return to Egypt. This points to the expiatory effect of the blood shed and smeared on Moses' feet."⁵⁰ While Kim is right that there is an expiatory effect to the shedding of Gershom's blood, as will be seen in 4:26, it is not

⁴⁴ Francis Brown, Samuel R. Driver, and Charles A. Briggs, "חתן," in *Brown-Driver-Briggs Lexicon*, 368; Ludwig Koehler, Walter Baumgartner, and Johann Jakob Stamm, "חתן," *Hebrew and Aramaic Lexicon of the Old Testament*, vol. 1, translated by M. E. J. Richardson (New York: Brill, 1994), 365; Dozeman, *Exodus*, 155; Propp, *Exodus*, 219; Houtman, *Exodus*, 444. For the most comprehensive study of חתן, see T. C. Mitchell, "Meaning of the Noun Chtn in the Old Testament," *Vetus Testamentum* 19, no. 1 (January 1969): 93-112.

⁴⁵ Becking, "Then Zipporah Took a Flint," 15.

⁴⁶ Propp, *Exodus*, 219-20.

⁴⁷ In addition to his commentary, see also Propp's earlier publication, "That Bloody Bridegroom (Exodus iv 24-6)." His article and commentary have had a significant impact on the study of this passage, as his view has been widely adopted.

⁴⁸ Kim, "Christotelic Interpretation," 12.

⁴⁹ Propp, *Exodus*, 234-35.

⁵⁰ Kim, "Christotelic Interpretation," 12.

to cover any guilt attached to Moses from his killing of an Egyptian. The problem with this approach lies in the meaning of “blood,” the analogy of a city of refuge, and verse 26 itself.

Although blood in the plural frequently refers to bloodshed or the guilt attached to a murderer, these are not the exclusive usages of the plural. The usage of the plural can be categorized more broadly as “abundance, blood in quantity.”⁵¹ It can refer to ordinary blood, such as menstrual bleeding in Leviticus 12:4-7 and 20:18 or to warfare, which would certainly not be considered murder or have implications of guilt (cf. Isa 9:5; 1 Chr 22:8).⁵² Bloodguilt is not inherent in the meaning of *damim*, and the word alone does not necessitate Zipporah referring to the murder of an Egyptian. In addition, interpreting Zipporah’s phrase in this way requires a lot of material to be read into the text. Propp is eager to compare the actions of Moses in Exodus 2–3 to fleeing to a city of refuge. However, there are no lexical links to support this connection, and neither Midian nor Sinai are presented as a city or mountain of refuge in Scripture. Furthermore, the concept of cities of refuge and specific laws outlined for the punishment of murderers is a concept found in the Mosaic law, but nowhere prior to Exodus 4. Taking a later system and imposing it on this text seems unwarranted. Understanding Zipporah’s use of *damim* with connotations of guilt overlooks other usages of the word and unnecessarily inserts later concepts into an earlier passage.

A better approach is to follow a straightforward reading of the phrase, “bridegroom of blood.” The overwhelming focus in the passage is on the actions taken: Yahweh seeks to execute Moses, Zipporah circumcises her son, and Yahweh releases Moses. Childs writes, “The whole emphasis of the passage [is] on circumcision . . . this is what saved Moses.”⁵³ The narrator neither gives information regarding the state of the individuals nor explains the meaning of Zipporah’s words. It is as if he wants the reader to focus on the intervening circumcision by Zipporah, not ultimately why Gershom was circumcised, but simply to emphasize that the blood of the son’s circumcision touched the feet of Moses. Keeping the focus on circumcision, without reading concepts of guilt and refuge into the text, leads to a plain understanding of the blood, used here in the plural to refer to a large amount of blood. It makes perfect sense for Zipporah to use the plural to refer to the actual blood of Gershom. Gershom was not an infant at this time, so he would have bled significantly from the circumcision, making the plural of blood appropriate to use. Gershom’s bleeding is excessive, and his bloody foreskin is touched to the feet of Moses. Zipporah’s words refer not to any supposed guilt of Moses, but to the circumcision she has just performed. The syntax of verse 26 makes this explicit.

וַיִּרְךָ מִקֵּנוֹ אֶזְרָא אֶתְּמִיחָה הַתַּנִּיחָה לְמוֹלֶת 4:26

“Then he released him. At that time, she said, ‘Bridegroom of blood,’ regarding the circumcision.”

⁵¹ Francis Brown, Samuel R. Driver, and Charles A. Briggs, “דם” In *Brown-Driver-Briggs Lexicon*, 196.

⁵² The usage of *damim* for warfare would fit with the meaning of quantity, as referring to the large amount of blood shed in war.

⁵³ Childs, *Exodus*, 100.

After Zipporah circumcises her son and declares Moses to be her bloody bridegroom, the focus shifts back to Yahweh with the phrase, “Then he released him.” Yahweh’s release of Moses means that the death threat has passed. This verb for release (רָפָה) refers to laziness, relaxing, letting something go, or becoming limp. Yahweh may have grasped Moses in 4:24, and now physically releases him in 4:26. Alternatively, the phrase could be understood to mean that the Lord departed from Moses. Either way, the meaning is clear—Moses’s life is no longer threatened by God.⁵⁴ The blood of Gershom’s circumcision touching the feet of Moses is enough for Yahweh to remove the sentence of death.

The narrative then concludes with an editorial phrase, “At that time she said, ‘Bridegroom of blood,’ regarding the circumcision.” The adverb of time (אָז) reiterates that Zipporah spoke the declaration after circumcising Gershom. This clarifies that the circumcision and release were the reason for the bloody bridegroom phrase. After repeating the phrase, Moses then shows through Zipporah’s words what it reference: “on account of the circumcision” (לְמִלּוּלָהּ). The bloody bridegroom phrase was spoken regarding the circumcision of Zipporah’s son. It is not necessary to read ideas about cities of refuge into the meaning of blood to understand Zipporah’s phrase, when the word לְמִלּוּלָהּ (“on account of the circumcision”) makes it plain. The phrase “bridegroom of blood” is used in relation to Zipporah’s circumcision of Gershom on Moses’s behalf, not in relation to Moses’s murderous past. Zipporah calls Moses a bloody bridegroom because of the blood of the circumcision that is touching his feet. Her words then appear to be a declaration of acceptance. Moses is her bridegroom, and their bond is not separated by death but sealed by blood. The circumcision joins Zipporah and Moses in a special way. In her declaration of “bridegroom of blood,” Zipporah affirms her union with the leader of God’s people. The feet of Moses are bloodied, but he is alive. Yahweh releases him to continue his return to Egypt. The salvation of Moses is accomplished by his wife, establishing his identity as a Hebrew through the ritual of circumcision. This is Moses’s Passover.

Biblical Theology

As seen in the exegesis of Exodus 4:24-26, Moses is saved from death at the hands of Yahweh by the blood of his son’s circumcision being touched to his feet. In Exodus 1–4, Moses has his life threatened by Pharaoh, is saved among the reeds, departs for the wilderness, and comes to the mountain of God. Then, in Exodus 4:20-31 he embarks on his return to Egypt. His salvation climaxes in the center of the return narrative—the bloody bridegroom account—in 4:24-26. Moses and his family lie down at the lodging-place at night, just as Israel gathered in their homes in the middle of the night (12:29). Yahweh meets Moses and seeks to put him to death, as he will pass through Egypt at night to put the firstborn sons to death (11:4-5; 12:29). Zipporah circumcises her son and causes his bloody foreskin to touch the feet of Moses. The sons of Israel slay the Passover lambs and cause the blood to touch the lintel and doorposts of their houses. When he sees the blood, Yahweh releases Moses and passes over the houses of Israel. The bloody bridegroom narrative is the Passover of Moses.

⁵⁴ Ibid., 104.

Moses ties the two Passover accounts together with the word “touch,” making the connection between the two narratives lexical, as well as thematic. As Morales observes, “The pattern of divine death threat avoided through the application of blood surely does bring us into the realm of Passover theology.”⁵⁵ As Moses escapes death when the blood is touched to his feet, so Israel would escape death when the blood was touched to their houses. Thus, Alexander concludes, “Here, as at the Passover, blood averts death.”⁵⁶ The Passover of Moses serves as the paradigm for the Passover of Israel.

Moses wrote Exodus 1–4, the story of his own exodus, to prepare the reader for the exodus of the nation in the following chapters. These verses, according to Fishbane, “anticipate the redemption of the Israelites, God’s own firstborn (cf. v. 23), by focusing on the salvation and protection effected for Moses by the blood of his own son’s circumcision.”⁵⁷ Israel’s deliverance is played out in the life of Moses, culminating in the passing over of the bloody bridegroom. In the words of Morales, “Moses had experienced a Passover deliverance himself even before the plagues in Egypt had begun. As Israel’s mediator, Moses was also Israel’s frontrunner in deliverance.”⁵⁸ Moses was saved in a Passover to prepare him to lead Israel in the Passover. Moses walked the path of individual exodus so that he could lead the nation in corporate exodus.

Conclusion

The bloody bridegroom narrative is framed in the context of salvation by women, the identity of Moses, and the covenant of circumcision. Moses transgressed the covenant by failing to circumcise his son. God comes to execute Moses for his sin, but Zipporah intervenes through circumcision. Having been previously saved by the midwives, his mother, his sister, and Pharaoh’s daughter, Moses is now saved by his own wife. The bloody bridegroom narrative also establishes his identity once and for all.⁵⁹ Moses may have been adopted by the Egyptians and lived with the Midianites, but he is commissioned to be the leader of God’s people. Through the circumcision of Gershom, Moses and his family are fully members of God’s covenant. Having been saved in his Passover, Moses can now lead Israel in the national Passover. Both Moses and Israel are saved from death at the hands of Yahweh by the touching of blood. The two Passover accounts point forward to the firstborn who sheds his blood in the ultimate Passover. Moses becomes Zipporah’s bloody bridegroom through the circumcision of his son. The people of God become his bloody bride through the death of his Son.

⁵⁵ L. Michael Morales, *Exodus Old and New: A Biblical Theology of Redemption* (Downers Grove, IL: IVP Academic, 2020), 75.

⁵⁶ Alexander, *Exodus*, 107.

⁵⁷ M. A. Fishbane, *Text and Texture: Close Readings of Selected Biblical Texts* (New York: Schocken, 1979), 71.

⁵⁸ Morales, *Exodus*, 75.

⁵⁹ See Pettit, “When the Lord Seeks to Kill Moses,” 172–74.